“acculturation in reverse” whereby the Spanish language, and Cuban culture, became dominant.[9]

Miami’s landscape was further complicated with the arrival of some 125,000 Cubans during the Mariel boatlift, which began in April 1980 when a small group of Cubans crashed a truck through the gates of the Peruvian Embassy in Havana and asked for asylum. Within days, some 10,000 had gathered there. People’s reasons for wanting to leave Cuba, Felix Masud-Piloto explains, included family reunification, “desire for a less regimented life in the United States,” desire for access to consumer goods, and political disenchantment – virtually the same reasons that motivated migrants from everywhere in Latin America. However, “these explanations did not convince observers and commentators outside Cuba, who almost invariably chose to interpret the events in strictly political terms.” Although the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees concluded that the Cubans in the Embassy were not refugees but simply people who wanted to emigrate, the U.S. President Carter agreed to “provide an open heart and open arms for the tens of thousands of refugees seeking freedom from Communist domination.” Castro, meanwhile, offered to open the Cuban port of Mariel to Miami Cubans who wanted to come and pick up their relatives. Tens of thousands took the two presidents up on their offers.[10] The United States scrambled to respond to the influx, setting up detention and processing centers and pressuring the Cuban government to close the port. In October 1980 Castro did so, and the boatlift ended.

The Mariel migrants were confronted with the social, cultural and political divide between Cubans and other Latino groups in the United States, and between Cubans in Miami and the changes occurring on the island. Miami’s Cubans had tried to recreate, and preserve, the Cuba of the 1950s, before the social changes of the 1960s that swept both Cuba and Latino groups into the United States. “They tried to duplicate the past so exactly,” explains María Cristina García, “that Cubans who arrived in Miami during the Mariel boatlift of 1980 often joked that they had entered a time warp and stepped back into the Cuba of the 1950s.”[11] And when new Cubans arrived in the 1980s, Miami’s Cuban